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THEY LIVE WELL BELOW THEIR MEANS.

The first time we interviewed a group of people worth at least \$10 million (decamillionaires), the session turned out differently than we had planned. We were contracted to study the wealthy by a large international trust company. Our client wanted us to study the needs of high-net worth individuals.

To make sure our decamillionaire respondents felt comfortable during the interview, we rented a posh penthouse on Manhattan's fashionable East Side. We also hired two gourmet food designers. They put together a menu of four pâtés and three kinds of caviar. To accompany this, the designers suggested a case of high-quality 1970 Bordeaux plus a case of a "wonderful" 1973 cabernet sauvignon.

Armed with what we thought would be the ideal menu, we enthusiastically awaited the arrival of our decamillionaire respondents. The first to arrive was someone we nicknamed Mr. Bud. Sixty-nine and a first-generation millionaire, Mr. Bud owned several valuable pieces of commercial real estate in the New York metropolitan area. He also owned two businesses. You would never have figured from his outward appearance that he was worth well over \$10 million. His dress was what you might call dull-normal—a well-worn suit and overcoat.

Nevertheless, we wanted to make Mr. Bud feel that we fully understood the food and drink expectations of America's decamillionaires. So after we introduced ourselves, one of us asked, "Mr. Bud, may I pour you a glass of 1970 Bordeaux?"

Mr. Bud looked at us with a puzzled expression on his face and then said: